

Rs 5 lakh and Rs 30 lakh to start an independent company. A garage label—an artiste producing his/her own album—will need only about Rs 5 lakh and 6 lakh, while a more professional one will need about Rs 30 lakh. Also, most new labels work only on one artiste at a time and so channel all resources in one direction. It can take an independent company anywhere between Rs 35 lakh and Rs 50 lakh to launch and promote a new artiste. This includes the video, distribution, production, and on and off air promotion too. "It can be done even in Rs 2 lakh but this won't include a video or any promotional activity," says Kumar.

Little wonder then that, instead of promoting an established artiste, Surapur is pushing the boys from Kerala and Mou, the girl from Bengal. "I'd rather use the money on them than on someone like Rabbi who's already got a platform now," he says. But when the money dries up, the going does get tough for the artistes. Some like Dixit survive by playing at concerts and composing jingles, while others like members of Avial have full-fledged recording studios that they give out on hire.

Noble intentions aside, money does play an important role and any musician, however great, cannot survive on strumming the guitar alone. Industry experts also say CD sales are depleting due to the Internet and extensive piracy, and labels don't make much money out of actual album sales. Surapur explains that most of the cost is recovered through live gigs, road shows, corporate events and other unconventional channels like tie-ups with gaming companies. Value-added mobile phone services such as caller back tunes, ringtones and downloads are also becoming a big source of revenue.

Music festivals are another way of creating a buzz around new artistes.

Last summer the Big Chill electronic dance festival landed in Goa and drew over 4,500 fans. It was organised by independent record label Counter Culture Records, a subdivision of artist management company Only Much Louder (OML) that was one of the first few to promote Indian talent. The recently concluded East Wind festival in Delhi too was a testimony to people's longing for new voices.

When the music isn't mainstream, the ways used to reach out aren't run-of-the-mill either. Instead of advertisements in newspapers, independent companies look for the road less travelled. Phatak says, "We plan to stock the records at coffee shops, bookstores, colleges and make them available at road shows." After all, if Alanis Morissette can make her record available only at Starbucks outlets and

DHRUV AND ASHU

Their company Blue Frog is a production, recording studio and an artiste management company all rolled into one. By April end it plans to roll out its first batch of artistes.



still do brisk business, why can't an Indian artiste? Using youth-based shows to their advantage also works. "We made rock band Agni record a song especially for the reality show *Roadies 5.0* and it's become their most downloaded song though it has no video," says Ashish Patil, vp and GM, content, MTV.

The Internet is another medium that record labels are excited about especially because today a 20-something will more often be found on Facebook than in a bookstore. "I'm telling all the free downloaders to rip my tracks off the Internet. Once they hear it, they'll buy the album," says Dixit. Within five days of being available on the music website musicyogi.com, Dixit's album was sold out. Surapur concludes, "Those who want to hear new music will find it. I want housewives to get hooked to Malyalee rock." With the 42-year-old on the third floor already sending an SMS to set Avial's *Nada nada* as her caller tune, Surapur might not have to wait too long.